Do Entrepreneurship Influencers Matter: Boosters of Entrepreneurship intent among University Students in Morocco

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Abstract

Purpose. Though entrepreneurship is one key driver of many countries' economy and an important player in the job creation process, its presence in Morocco is still relatively low. The current study aimed to investigate the determinants of entrepreneurship intentions among university students in Morocco, using the Theory of Planned Behavior and the Social Learning Theory. The moderating effect of gender, university type, self-efficacy, and prior entrepreneurship exposure was also explored.
Design/Methodology/Approach. Data was collected via a survey of 272 Moroccan participants, analyzed using the partial least squares (PLS) technique.
Findings. Attitude towards entrepreneurship is a key predictor of entrepreneurship intention. At the same time, subjective norms as well as inspiring entrepreneurial role models are a key determinant of a positive attitude towards entrepreneurship. Trustworthiness is an important factor in determining attitude towards influencers. Adding to that, self-efficacy and prior entrepreneurship exposure play a direct role in determining entrepreneurship intention.
Managerial Implications. Entrepreneurial intentions of Moroccan students are mainly shaped through role model inspiration and social support, which suggests to move towards more practical learning, inclusive policies, and shifting societal perceptions to cultivate a successful entrepreneurial ecosystem.
Originality/Value. The study contributes to the entrepreneurial research field by examining the role of entrepreneurship influencers, subjective norms, as well as role models. Based on our current information, this study is the first in Morocco to investigate the role that entrepreneurship influencers play in determining entrepreneurial intentions among the youth.
Key Words. Role models, subjective norms, entrepreneurship, influencers, Morocco.

1. Introduction

Entrepreneurship is vital to any nation as it is a key player in economic growth and the creation of new job opportunities (Rusu, 2017). Since the early 2010's, Morocco has placed a great emphasis on entrepreneurship. In 2015, Morocco has officially introduced the "entrepreneur" status to encourage informal workers to register legally and benefit from social security (Ministère de l'Industrie et du Commerce, 2015). Furthermore, in 2020, an initiative was launched to provide financial support and encouragement to young entrepreneurs, small businesses, and startups under the name "Intilaka", with a budget of 7.75 billion dirhams (BAM, 2021) The importance of entrepreneurship is also mentioned in the message from His Majesty the King Mohammed VI at

the Fifth Edition of the Global Entrepreneurship Summit: “Entrepreneurship and innovation are twin values that serve as springboards to freedom, social mobility, and prosperity” (2014). In 2023, ANAPEC introduced “Génération Entrepreneurs” to assist 100,000 project holders and very small enterprises (VSEs) by 2026 (Ministère de l’Inclusion économique, de la Petite entreprise, de l’Emploi et des Compétences, 2023). Following this, the “Association des Femmes Chefs d'Entreprises du Maroc” *(*AFEM) created in 2024 the “She Impulse” program with the collaboration of the Ministry of Industry and Trade to provide support to women with entrepreneurial projects through the “She Start”; one of three pillars dedicated to supporting Moroccan women (Ministère de l’Industrie et du Commerce, 2024). Despite these programs, Morocco's official unemployment rate is still high, as it reached 13.3% in 2024 (HCP, 2024). On top of that, statistics from the 2024 General Census report an outrageous rate; jumping from 16.2% in 2014 to 21.3% in 2024, with women's unemployment standing at 25.9%, indicating deeper structural issues in the labor market (HCP, 2024). Youngsters are worst off with unemployment reaching 39.5% in the third quarter of 2024 (HCP, 2024). These startling rates highlight the increasing employment crisis. In addition, in 2023, over 80% of new business owners reported unemployment as the critical reason to start their businesses (GEM, 2024). This data strongly suggests that the majority of entrepreneurial activity within the country is driven by need instead of opportunity. This illustrates the "refugee effect" mentioned in the literature, where the pressure of high unemployment drives young people into self-employment (Aubry et al., 2015). However, entrepreneurship itself has been proven to have a bidirectional and nonlinear relation with unemployment (Faria et al., 2010). Concurrently, university-level learners in Morocco offer a distinctive and highly applicable population for the current research. As digital natives, they have been exposed to the internet and smartphones from a very young age and their attitudes and aspirations are profoundly influenced by digital culture (Chang & Chang, 2023). Although the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB) has prevailed in the entrepreneurial intention research (Pham et al., 2023; Liu et al., 2019), it has been blamed for its individualistic nature and exclusion of social learning processes like role models and influencer influence (Zhao et al., 2005). In contrast, the Social Learning Theory (SLT) emphasizes observational learning and modeling (Nabi et al., 2018; Zozimo et al., 2017), but it has seldom been merged with TPB to explore how psychological and social mechanisms coalesce to influence entrepreneurial action. This research is the first to synthesize TPB and SLT to explore entrepreneurial intentions among academic youth in Moroccan universities, who are ever more exposed to digital media and influencers. While marketing studies have confirmed that trust and identification with influencers affect consumer behavior (Lou & Kim, 2019; Shan et al., 2019; Rudeloff & Damms, 2023), their role in shaping entrepreneurial attitudes is still understudied. Thus, there is a clear lack of empirical research on this matter, particularly among Moroccan university students. In addition, this study addresses the rising demand in entrepreneurship research for a better understanding of non-traditional role models such as social media influencers (Amofah & Saladrigues, 2022; Abbasianchavari & Moritz, 2021). Concepts like identification with influencers and attitudes toward influencer-based entrepreneurship have been studied in related domains (Balaban et al., 2021; Schouten et al., 2021) but are yet to be fully

theorized in entrepreneurship research. Apart from the above, the research examines the moderating effect of entrepreneurial self-efficacy on the attitude-intention relationship, specifically in relation with educational psychology and entrepreneurship research (Santos & Liguori, 2020; Elnadi & Gheith, 2021). The research accounts for contextual moderators like previous entrepreneurial exposure, entrepreneurship education, gender, and type of university to determine their effect on entrepreneurial intention development. This study contributes theoretically in several ways. First, it proposes and tests attitudes toward entrepreneurship influencers as a mediating factor, providing a new perspective on how influencer attributes influence entrepreneurial thinking. Moreover, it integrates the TPB model with SLT principles, closing the gap between intention and social learning at a personal level. Practically, the results provide useful intelligence to educators, policymakers, and opinion leaders. For educators, this study will help them better understand the position of young individuals toward entrepreneurship influencers, enabling them to incorporate adapted content in course materials in entrepreneurship education that enhance the engagement and entrepreneurial attitudes. Policymakers can utilize the knowledge to craft more targeted interventions, especially in public universities where support can vary. When recognizing how entrepreneurial influencers affect students' intentions, they can design initiatives and programs that resonate with youth culture. Lastly, the research empowers entrepreneurial influencers by acknowledging their impact and responsibility in influencing real-world entrepreneurial behavior. The remainder of this paper is organized as follows: Section 2 covers the literature review, and Section 3 describes the research methods. The results are then presented in Section 4. Then the discussion, implications, and limitations are illustrated in Section 5.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Theoretical Framework

The theory of planned behavior (TPB) developed by Ajzen (2011) suggests that attitude, subjective norms and perceived behavioral control influence an individual’s intention to perform a particular behavior. TPB is one of the most used theories to explain human behavior in a variety of settings (Entrialgo and Iglesias, 2016). Subjective norms refer to the perceived social pressure of an individual's surroundings that will push them to perform a certain behavior or not (Manning, 2009). Attitude is the positive or negative evaluation of a behavior (Ajzen, 2011) while perceived behavioral control refers to the personal assessment of the ease or difficulty to perform that behavior (Kidwell et al., 2003).TPB in entrepreneurship research has been widely used to develop models that link a positive attitude towards entrepreneurship, subjective norms (role models, influencers...etc) and perceived behavioral control or self-efficacy to entrepreneurial intentions (Krueger et al., 2000; Liñán & Chen, 2009).

The Social Learning Theory (SLT) is another theory that may help understand entrepreneurial intentions. First developed by Albert Bandura (1977), it argues that individuals

develop attitudes and behaviors by observing others. It is believed that individuals learn within a social environment by observing others whom they can relate to and who demonstrate strong performance in a field they are interested in or aspire to succeed in essentially, learning through example or modeling (Bosma et al., 2012). SLT's learning process has four steps: attention, retention, motor production, and motivation (Bandura, 1977). In entrepreneurship research, SLT has been widely used to understand how individuals' intentions towards entrepreneurship are influenced by observing successful entrepreneurs (Nabi et al., 2018; Zozimo et al., 2017). In the context of Morocco, we investigate whether youth will tend to have entrepreneurial intentions if he grows up in a family of entrepreneurs or is exposed to entrepreneurial role models (Harinie et al., 2017).

2.2 Hypothesis Development

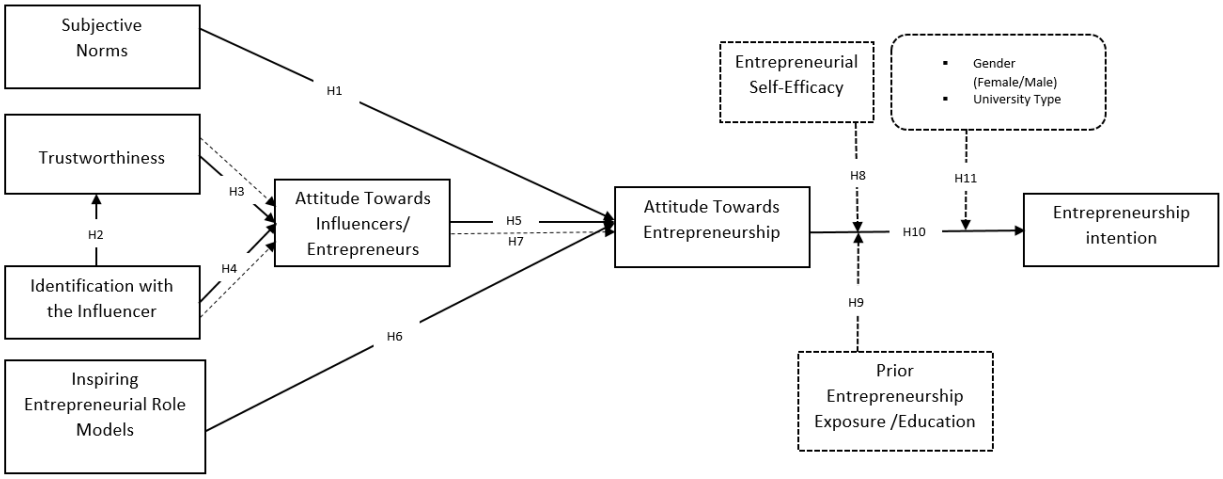

Figure 1 Conceptual Model

While attitude generally refers to the positive or negative evaluation of a behavior (Ajzen, 2011), In the framework of entrepreneurial intentions, attitude can be considered as the degree to which an individual thinks positively or negatively of entrepreneurship (Pham et al., 2023). It corresponds to the extent in which people perceive entrepreneurship as satisfying and worthwhile (Nowiński and Haddoud, 2019). TPB proposes that attitude, subjective norms and control toward the behavior directly play a role in engaging in certain behaviors (Ajzen, 2011). Subjective norms represent the social pressure exerted by individuals that influence the evaluation of a certain behavior (Liu et al., 2019). Individuals will tend to plan their behavior by taking into consideration their surroundings' influence through family, friends, roles models... (Crandall et al., 2002). When an individual's surrounding think that entrepreneurship is a good career decision and will generate more income than a salary, the latter will evaluate entrepreneurship as a positive thing (Pham et al., 2023), which will then affect their attitude towards entrepreneurship. Based on the above: **H1.** Subjective Norms have a significant relationship with Attitude Towards Entrepreneurship.

Identification with an influencer is the degree to which followers recognize similarity or emotional affinity with the values, lifestyle, or persona of the influencer. Such perceived similarity supports parasocial interactions, one-sided psychological relationships, that are fundamental for establishing perceived trust (Yılmazdoğan et al., 2021). When followers identify closely with influencers, they are more likely to see them as credible, honest, and sincere (Kim et al., 2021). Trustworthiness, being one of the key elements of source credibility, is positively affected by emotional proximity and perceived authenticity, both of which are consequences of close identification (Schouten et al., 2021). In entrepreneurial settings, where influencers are often informal role models or educators, this identification is even more powerful in influencing followers' perceptions of their trustworthiness (Balaban et al., 2021). Followers who identify with an entrepreneurial influencer are more likely to see them as trustworthy, and identification is a strong predictor of perceived trustworthiness.
H2. Identification with the influencer has a significant relationship with Trustworthiness.

Another factor that could be linked to attitude towards entrepreneurship influencers is an individual's perceived trustworthiness of an entrepreneurship influencer. The term influencers generally refers to social media stars or micro celebrities that promote content on the internet on a chosen topic of interest (Gaenssle and Budzinski, 2021).Trustworthiness is the degree of confidence that one places on a third party when they observe a certain level or reliability, honesty and believability (AlFarraj et al., 2021). Perceived trustworthiness of the influencer is the degree to which followers see an influencer as honest, credible and sincere (Erdogan, 1999; Ohanian,1990; Countinho et al., 2023). Previous work has demonstrated that influencers need to keep a certain level of trust with their audience to effectively promote products and services (Schouten et al., 2021), in this case entrepreneurship can be considered as the promoted product. Additionally, the perceived trustworthiness is a primary factor that will dictate the subsequent behavior (Balaban et al., 2021). Drawing on signaling theory, when little information is available, trust will have a significant influence on one's attitude (Shamim and Islam, 2022) In the entrepreneurial context, people are expected to willingly be vulnerable when exposed to an entrepreneurship influencer's actions and words when not enough information is available and hence letting their trust influence their attitude towards that entrepreneurship influencer. Based on these arguments, it has been postulated that:
H3. Perceived Trustworthiness of the Influencer positively influences Attitude towards Entrepreneurship Influencers.

Identification with the influencer is another variable which affects attitude towards entrepreneurship influencers. According to Cohen (2001), it is an interactive and dynamic process in which individuals temporarily take on an influencer's goals, emotions, and viewpoints, going beyond mere acknowledgment of similarity in values or admiration and consists of intense intellectual and emotional identification with the influencer. On social media, they are typically engaging with entrepreneurial influencers whose success stories, failures, and transparency provide fertile ground for such identification (Lou & Kim, 2019). Similarly, if the influencer's

perceived motives are seen as genuine such as a desire to inspire or help others rather than purely to profit; this can strengthen parasocial identification and increase the influence of their endorsements on followers' attitudes and intentions (Shan, Y., Chen, K., & Lin, J., 2019). Based on the above, we postulate that:
H4. Identification with the Influencer positively affects Attitude towards Entrepreneurs and Influencers.

TPB argues that attitude is the main antecedent of behavioral intentions (Ajzen, 2011). While attitude towards influencers refers to the personal assessment an individual makes that reflects their like or dislike towards a person involved in a particular event (Mardhiah & Widod, 2023). It is also the general evaluation, beliefs and feelings that people have towards those influencers (Ilieva et al., 2024). Entrepreneurship influencers are traditional entrepreneurs and social media users that start creating content related to their personal business (Guinez-Cabrera et al., 2025). A social media influencer can influence a person's behavior and norms and lead them to acquire the same attitude (Tran, 2025). In the framework that influencers can be considered role models or mentors, they are expected to exert a sort of para social mentoring that will shape their followers' attitude towards entrepreneurship (D'Oria et al., 2025), a para social relationship occurs when a person develops a feeling of intimacy and identification with a celebrity (Um, 2013). Building on these arguments, we construct the following hypothesis.
H5. Attitude towards Entrepreneurship influencers positively influence Attitude towards Entrepreneurship.

From SLT, another factor that is linked to attitude towards entrepreneurship are role models (Nowiński and Haddoud, 2019; Amofah and Saladrigues, 2022).Role models are individuals who inspire people to decide on certain career choices and consitute a positive source of influence to set up ambitious goals (Sijabat, 2024; Morgenroth et al., 2015) since engaging in a certain behavior is usually influenced by other's opinions and actions (Karimi et al., 2014). Exposure to entrepreneurial role models (in parents, mentors or entrepreneurship influencers) increases perception of desirability and feasibility of entrepreneurial action, which strengthen the personal attitude towards entrepreneurship (Nowiński and Haddoud, 2019), it also creates an environment that feed entrepreneurial intentiosn among people (Abbasianchavari and Moritza, 2021). Based on the above:
H6. Inspiring entrepreneurial role models have a significant relationship with Attitudes towards entrepreneurship.

Little research examines the mediation role of attitude towards entrepreneurship influencers; in fact, this variable is still relatively new. A follower will be assured that their relationship with an influencer will affect them positively when trust exists between the two (Kim and Kim, 2021). For a positive perception of a promoted product to exit, there must be a perceived trustworthiness of an influencer (Hofeditz et al., 2022). Identification is also important in determining attitude and behavior as people who strongly identify with a celebrity are more likely

to mirror her thoughts, feelings, and behaviors than those who don't relate to her (Um, 2013). Building on this, when influencers portray themselves authentically, then their followers are most likely to be inspired by their entrepreneurial orientations, which can subsequently make entrepreneurship a more desirable and attainable career choice (Agnihotri et al., 2023). This effect is further amplified through parasocial relationships, which nurture trust while decreasing psychological distance, rendering the influencer more persuasive (Cohen, 2001; Rudeloff & Damms, 2023).By establishing a connection between the influencer and the followers, entrepreneurship is indirectly exposed to the followers, thus increasing the appeal and feasibility of entrepreneurship as a valid career option and lifestyle choice especially when an individual shows high trust and identification towards that influencer. Accordingly, it is hypothesized that: **H7**. Attitude towards Entrepreneurship Influencers mediates the linkage between Trustworthiness, Identification with the Influencer and Attitude towards Entrepreneurship

Entrepreneurial self-efficacy (ESE) is confidence in one's capacity to successfully carry out entrepreneurship tasks (Bandura, 1977). It is a powerful indicator of entrepreneurial intention which reflects an individual's determination to launch a new venture (Krueger & Carsrud, 1993). As per the Social Cognitive Theory, ESE directly predicts entrepreneurial intention and also moderates attitude-intention relationship through its influence on difficulty management with confidence (Tiwari et al., 2017; Piperopoulos & Dimov, 2015). Scholars in measuring ESE use existing measures such as Chen et al.'s (1998) and Schjoedt and Craig's (2017), which are reliable and have high predictive validity. Empirical research demonstrates a strong positive relationship between entrepreneurial intention and ESE (Wilson et al., 2007; Shinnar et al., 2018), although some research indicates contextual moderators such as gender and culture (Elnadi & Gheith, 2021). Besides, entrepreneurship education and mentoring have also been seen to enhance ESE, hence generating more robust intentions and entrepreneurial behavior (Santos & Liguori, 2020). ESE is therefore a crucial psychological construct that not only exists alongside attitude but also dictates whether positive attitudes are translated to entrepreneurial action. We therefore presume that: **H8.** Entrepreneurial self-efficacy moderates the linkage between attitude towards entrepreneurship and entrepreneurial intention.

Previous entrepreneurial experience is a concept referring to a person's background and activities concerning entrepreneurship, including entrepreneurial parents or working in a startup or small business (Krueger, 1993; Peterman & Kennedy, 2003). It is a key predictor of entrepreneurial capacity and attitude by way of firsthand familiarity with the entrepreneurial process (Pittaway & Cope, 2007). Yet, most of the literature ignores the qualitative aspect of such experiences, whether they were positive or negative, that can condition their effect (Carr & Sequeira, 2007; Kim, Aldrich, & Keister, 2006). Such omission may be the reason for contradictory results since positive ones may energize and motivate individuals, but negative ones demotivate entrepreneurial pursuit (Krueger, 1993; Auken, et al., 2006). To this extent, entrepreneurship education also plays a central role as it evokes knowledge, skills, and self-

efficacy, and subsequently, entrepreneurial attitudes and entrepreneurial intentions (Peterman & Kennedy, 2003; Nabi et al., 2017). Intriguingly, current studies indicate that previous entrepreneurial exposure or education may have an influence on the entrepreneurial attitude and intention relationship. For instance, Zhang et al. (2019) found individuals with prior exposure to have a stronger relationship between positive attitudes and intentions since their exposure renders entrepreneurship more feasible and desirable. Similarly, Malebana & Mahlaole (2023) demonstrated that entrepreneurial exposure quality and frequency strengthen the relationship through the facilitation of psychological and emotional capital necessary for the enactment of positive attitudes. Similarly, entrepreneurship education is also in the identical relationship because it provides individuals with the competences, mentality, and self-assurance to become entrepreneurs (Sánchez, 2013). Based on the above:
H9. Prior entrepreneurship exposure and/or education moderate the linkage between attitude towards entrepreneurship and entrepreneurial intention.

Attitude towards entrepreneurship refers to an individual's positive or negative mindset towards being an entrepreneur, which summarizes a perception of its value, satisfaction, and attractiveness (Liñán & Chen, 2009). Entrepreneurial intention is an intended frame of mind, preceding action, and directing individual attention, experience, and action towards the formation of an enterprise (Bird, 1988). Numerous empirical studies have demonstrated that attitude is one of the most significant predictors of entrepreneurial intention. For example, Liñán, Rodríguez-Cohard, and Rueda-Cantuche (2011) found that students with favorable attitudes toward entrepreneurship were more likely to develop strong entrepreneurial intentions. Similarly, Popescu et al. (2016) established that when individuals are satisfied with entrepreneurship and find fulfillment personally, entrepreneurial intention is enhanced. These findings support the fact that a positive disposition towards entrepreneurship greatly enhances the possibility of forming the intention to be an actively entrepreneurially engaged individual.
H10. Attitude towards entrepreneurship has a significant relationship with Entrepreneurship Intention.

Previous studies suggest that gender influence attitude towards entrepreneurship and entrepreneurial intentions (Díaz-García et al., 2010; Datta et al., 2022). Researchers argues that both female and male show similar formation of entrepreneurship intentions, however, male show more preference and interest to business creation (Feder et al., 2017). Women tend to see entrepreneurship as a male oriented career due to societal norms and the lack of female role models (Díaz-García et al., 2010). When it comes to self-efficacy, differences also exist as women tend to see themselves as less capable of launching entrepreneurial ventures due, sometimes, to societal prejudices (Dempsey and Jennings, 2014). Another moderator that is proposed is the university type that an individual attends. In the case of this research three types exist: Public universities, private, and semi-private ones. The environment that is offered by both public and private universities is different. It is then expected that entrepreneurship intentions among post-millennial cohort will be different (Barral et al., 2018). A Brazilian study shows that private university

students are more exposed to entrepreneurial education than those from public universities (Canever et al., 2017). On the other hand, another research from Malaysia shows that students from public universities have higher entrepreneurial intentions (Pihie et al., 2013). Accordingly, to test and to add to the literature review, we suggest gender and university type as moderators in the relationship between attitude towards entrepreneurship and entrepreneurial intentions.
H11a: Gender moderates the relationship between attitude towards entrepreneurship and entrepreneurship intentions.
H11b: University type moderates the relationship between attitude towards entrepreneurship and entrepreneurship intentions.

3.Methods

3.1 Procedures

Morocco's selection for the study is due to the growing interest the nation holds on entrepreneurship. According to OMPIC, 95 235 enterprises were created in 2024. Yet, recent statistics from HCP shows that unemployment among the youth reached 36.7%, 19.6% among graduates and 19.4% among female (2024).

Table 1 Survey Respondents demographic characteristics (N=272)

Measure	Item	N	(%)	Measure	Item	N	(%)
Gender	Female	147	54.04%	**Education**	Bachelor	230	84.56%
	Male	125	45.96%		Master	38	13.97%
					PhD	4	1.47%
Age	18-25 years old	263	96.69%	**University Type**	Public	92	33.82%
	26-30 years old	8	2.94%		Private	36	13.24%
	31- 40 years old	1	0.37%		Semi-Private	144	52.94%
City of origin	Casablanca-Settat	70	25.74%	**Field of Study**	Business and Economics	107	39.34%
	Rabat-Salé-Kénitra	99	36.40%		Health and Medicine	23	8.46%
	Marrakech-Safi	5	1.84%		Science and Technology	81	29.78%
	Fès-Meknes	38	13.97%		Humanities and Social Sciences	25	9.19%
	Tanger-Tétouan-Al Hoceima	17	6.25%		Arts and Design	8	2.94%
	Other regions	43	15.81%		Linguistics	2	0.74%
					Other	26	9.56%

With an entrepreneurial rate of 15.05 in 2024 according to GEM, we want to understand what influences entrepreneurial intentions among the Moroccan youth, and especially among university students.

To guarantee a good representativeness of the target population, we opted for the snowball sampling technique. Snowball sampling is a non-probability sampling technique where one member of the population introduces the research to other members of that population (Turner, 2020). This technique is convenient for finding unattainable populations. To get information, the target population was first approached by convenience in person, by phone, and via social media (Instagram, LinkedIn) and then asked to share the study with their respective network

3.2 Measurement

This study considers nine variables. All constructs were adapted, with minor modifications, from previous literature. The constructs were assessed using a five-point scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). Demographic questions related to age, gender, income, city of origin, employment status, university type, and field of study were incorporated at the end of the questionnaire. The study was conducted in English and French, as English is widely used among the youngest adult generation and is the second foreign language in Morocco (R'boul, 2022), while French being the most common language used in higher education (R'boul, 2024). We proceeded by analyzing the measurement model in terms of internal consistency, convergent and discriminant validity to finally assessing the structural model.

4. Results

As illustrated in Table 1, our sample gender distribution is relatively balanced with 147 female respondents (54.04%) and 125 male respondents (45.96%). When it comes to age, the most common range is the 18-25 years old with 263 respondents (96.69%), followed by the 26-30 years old group with 8 respondents (2.94%), and finally the 31-40 years old group with 1 respondent (0.37%). Regarding the geographical distribution of the participants, 36.40% are from the Rabat-Sale-Kenitra region, 25.74% are from Casablanca-Settat, 13.97% from Fez-Meknes, 6.25% from Tanger-Tetouan, 1.84% from Marrakech-Safi, and all the other region combined represents 15.81%. Regarding the level of study, 84.56% are pursuing a Bachelor, 13.97% for master students, and finally 1.47% for PhD level. Regarding the type of university respondents attend, 33.82% are from public universities, 52.94% are from semi-private institutions, and 13.24% are from private ones. Finally, for the field of study, Business and Economics occupy the first place with 39.34%, followed by Science and Technology 29.78%, then 9.19% for Humanities and Social Sciences, 8.46% for Health and Medicine, Arts and Design represents 2.94%, Linguistics 0.74%, and finally all the other categories united 9.56%: To analyze the causal relationship and assess the conceptual model, structured equation modeling (SEM) was employed. SEM is a statistical technique that uses latent variables to examine structural models (Chetioui et al., 2024). Due to the complexity of the proposed conceptual model, the use of partial least squares (PLS) was considered to be

appropriate (Hair et al., 2019). It was used to assess both the validation of the measurement model that determines indicator reliability, construct reliability, convergent validity and discriminant validity, and to assess the structural model that determines the causal relationships between proposed constructs.

4.1 Assessment of the measurement model

As shown on Table 2, the results indicate that all items' loadings are above the threshold of 0.6 except for SN1 and TRU3, values as low as 0.6 are considered acceptable as long as other indicators of construct validity are adequate (Hair et al., 2019).

Table 2 Factor loadings, composite reliabilities, Cronbach's alpha and average variance extracted (n=272)

Constructs	Loadings	CA	CR	AVE	Constructs	Loadings	CA	CR	AVE
Attitude towards Entrepreneurship		0.925	0.925	0.804	**Prior Entrepreneurship Education**		0.786	0.788	0.559
AttEnt 1	0.958				**PEE 1**	0.598			
AttEnt 2	0.89				**PEE 2**	0.813			
AttEnt3	0.839				**PEE 3**	0.811			
Attitude towards entrepreneurship influencer		0.891	0.891	**0.733**	**Self-Efficacy**		0.808	0.808	0.585
AttInf 1	0.954				**SE 1**	0.83			
AttInf 2	0.784				**SE 2**	0.779			
AttInf 3	0.821				**SE 3**	0.679			
Entrepreneurship Intention		0.835	0.836	0.632	**Subjective Norms**		0.734	0.734	0.58
EI1	0.83				**SN 1**	0.747			
EI2	0.846				**SN 2**	0.777			
EI3	0.701								
Inspiring Entrepreneurial Role Models		0.884	0.885	0.72	**Trustworthiness**		0.696	0.7	0.539
IERM 1	0.8				**TRU 1**	0.683			
IERM 2	0.922				**TRU 2**	0.782			
IERM 3	0.819								
Identification towards Influencers		0.823	0.823	0.608					
Identif 1	0.801								
Identif 2	0.755								
Identif 3	0.782								

With regards to construct reliability, we used Cronbach's alpha (CA) and composite reliability (CR). Our results suggest that all our construct have reliability above 0.7, with rounding for trustworthiness, which confirms the construct reliability. The convergent validity was assessed using the average variance extracted (AVE), that was above the threshold (0.5) for all constructs, approving the model's convergent validity. The discriminant validity was assessed using the heterotrait-monotrait (HTMT). According to the results, all HTMT values are below 0.9, which

confirms the discriminant validity (The HTMT table is available upon request). Upon assessing the convergent and discriminant validities, it is determined that all constructs can be used to verify the conceptual model.

4.2 Assessment of structural model

This study used a 5000 resample bootstrapping to assess the coefficient path significance. The coefficient of determination (R-square). The coefficient of determination should be above 0.33 (Lebdaoui et al., 2021). Our results suggest an R-square of 0.654 for trustworthiness, 0.784 for attitude towards influencers, 0.637 for attitude towards entrepreneurship and 0.869 for entrepreneurship intention.

Table 3 Total effects

Hypothesis	Relationship		Total effects	
			β	P-value
H1	Subjective Norms	➞Attitude toward Entrepreneurship	0.567	**0.000**
H2	Identification with the Entrepreneurship Influencer	➞Trustworthiness	0.809	**0.000**
H3	Trustworthiness	➞Attitude toward Influencer	0.898	**0.002**
H4	Identification with the Entrepreneurship Influencer	➞Attitude toward Influencer	-0.016	**0.957**
H5	Attitude toward Influencer	➞Attitude toward Entrepreneurship	0.035	**0.660**
H6	Inspiring Entrepreneurial Role Models	➞Attitude toward Entrepreneurship	0.229	**0.014**
H10	Attitude toward Entrepreneurship	➞Entrepreneurship Intention	0.776	**0.000**
Moderating effect				
H8	Entrepreneurial Self Efficacy* Attitude toward Entrepreneurship	➞Attitude toward Entrepreneurship	0.081	**0.133**
H9	Prior Entrepreneurship Exposure/Education* Attitude toward Entrepreneurship	➞Attitude toward Entrepreneurship	0.074	**0.409**
H11a	Gender* Attitude toward Entrepreneurship	➞Attitude toward Entrepreneurship	-0.211	0.226
H11b	University Type* Attitude toward Entrepreneurship	➞Attitude toward Entrepreneurship	0.082	**0.086**

As expected, subjective norms have a positive and significant relationship on attitude towards entrepreneurship (ß=0.567, p-value < 0.05), supporting H1. Individuals whose environment has a positive attitude towards entrepreneurship are more likely to do so too. It was also found that subjective norms have a direct and significant relationship with entrepreneurship intentions (ß=0.440, p-value < 0.05), highlighting that social norms do not only shape attitude but can also motivate entrepreneurship intentions. Identification with the influencer, was found to significantly and positively lead to trustworthiness (ß=0.809, p-value < 0.05), supporting H2. That is when people identify with a certain influencer, they will have a higher trust level toward them. Based on the results, it is also suggested that trustworthiness has a positive and significant relationship with the attitude towards the entrepreneurship influencer (ß=0.898, p-value < 0.05), supporting H3. Conversely, identification does not have a significant relationship with the attitude towards the entrepreneurship influencer (ß=-0.016, p-value > 0.05), rejecting H4. One explanation

that was suggested by other scholars is that while people may identify with an influencer, if the latter is perceived as inauthentic or driven by profit, there won't necessarily be a positive attitude towards them (Audrezet et al., 2020). Adding to that, results show that attitude towards entrepreneurship influencers does not have a significant relationship with attitude towards entrepreneurship (ß=0.035, p-value > 0.05), rejecting H5. This can be explained as a perceived lack of credibility towards the influencer or competency. Results also indicate that there is no mediating role of attitude towards the influencer between trustworthiness, identification with the influencer and attitude towards entrepreneurship, rejecting H7. With regards to inspiring entrepreneurial role models, results suggest that, as expected, there is a significant and positive relationship between inspiring entrepreneurial role model and attitude towards entrepreneurship (ß=0.229, p-value < 0.05), supporting H6, but there is also a direct, positive, and significant relationship with entrepreneurship intentions (ß=0.178, p-value < 0.05). Which means that a role model can directly be a source of motivation for entrepreneurship intention. For the moderating effect of prior entrepreneurship education, there seems to be no significant moderation (ß=0.074, p-value > 0.05), but results suggest a direct relationship with entrepreneurship intention (ß=0.240, p-value < 0.05). Self-Efficacy was also found not to have any significant role as a moderator (ß=0.081, p-value > 0.05) but rather as directly positively influencing entrepreneurship intention (ß=0.176, p-value < 0.05). This suggests that prior entrepreneurship education and self-efficacy can independently foster student's entrepreneurial intentions. University type was not found to have a significant effect as a moderator (ß=0.082, p-value > 0.05). Gender was, on the other hand, found to have no moderating role between attitude towards entrepreneurship and entrepreneurship intention. Finally, attitude towards entrepreneurship is found to have a significant relationship with entrepreneurship intention (ß=0.776, p-value < 0.05).

5. Discussion and conclusions

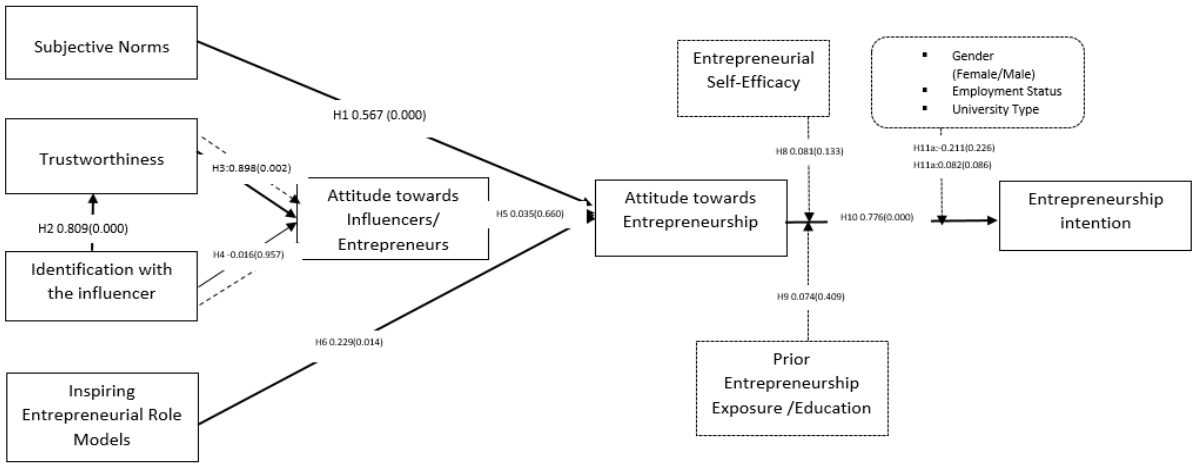

Figure 2: structural model results

This study aimed at determining the key variables that drive entrepreneurship intentions among university students in Morocco, while taking into consideration the contribution of entrepreneurship influencers. The moderating effect of self-efficacy, prior entrepreneurship education, as well as gender and university type were taken into account. TPB and SLT were taken as initial theories that could explain our conceptual model's different constructs. Out of eleven hypotheses, six were accepted and five were rejected.

First, subjective norms were found to have a significant relationship with attitude toward entrepreneurship. This goes with the findings of previous literatures (Ruiz-Rosa et al., 2020). Individuals whose surroundings have a positive attitude towards entrepreneurship are more likely to develop a higher and more positive attitude towards entrepreneurship. In the Moroccan context, where family opinion often heavily influences career decisions, this could suggest that enhancing family acceptance of entrepreneurship as a career choice could be a key determinant in boosting entrepreneurship. Inspiring entrepreneurial role models were also found to have a positive and significant influence on attitude towards entrepreneurship, which is consistent with the findings of previous literature (Nowiński and Haddoud, 2019). That is, individuals who are exposed to role models in the field of entrepreneurship are more likely to develop a positive attitude towards entrepreneurship. Students who observe succeeding entrepreneurs are expected to internalize the idea of success and the ease of doing it. With regards to attitude towards entrepreneurship influencers, a novel construct in entrepreneurship research. Two main antecedents were analyzed: trustworthiness and identification with the influencer. Based on the results, trustworthiness was found to positively influence attitudes towards entrepreneurship influencers, highlighting the importance for influencers to keep a certain trust level among their followers. Prior literature has shown that a lack of trustworthiness may affect attitude towards influencers, supporting the idea that people are more influenced by people they judge trustowrthy (Djafarova and Trofimenko, 2019). Identification was found to be significantly related to trustworthiness. Individuals who identify with influencers will have a higher level of trust towards them. However, identification was surprisingly found not to have any significant relationship with attitude towards influencers, and this may be explained by a cognitive dissonance or a lack of authenticity. The theory of cognitive dissonance suggests that when an individual is exposed to two or more contradictory cognitions, they will be in an uncomforting position or dissonance (Festinger, 1957). If an individual identifies with an influencer but experiences a dissonance in terms of moral ethics or behavior coming from that influencer, that may lead to a negative or neutral attitude. In other words, people may like or follow an influencer, but if they deem him as inauthentic or opportunistic, the would be less likely to take his advice. It suggests that relating or identifying to an influencer is not enough to build a positive perception of them

Surprisingly, Attitude towards entrepreneurship influencers itself was found not to have any significant relationship with attitude towards entrepreneurship. This could also be explained using the theory of cognitive dissonance or because of a perceived lack of authenticity. As Lou and Yuan (2019) explained, an influencer's credibility is crucial in determining how their followers would develop an attitude towards a domain, entrepreneurship in particular. If students

perceive influencers as entertainers or marketers rather than successful business owners, their influence on career decisions and promoting entrepreneurship would be inefficient.

The current study also assessed the moderating effect of prior entrepreneurship education or exposure, as well as self-efficacy, gender, and university type. While prior entrepreneurship education and self-efficacy were found not to have any roles as moderators, results indicate that they are directly linked to entrepreneurship intention (Liu et al., 2019). Since this study was mainly conducted among the youth, this may explain why gender is not found to have any significant role as a moderator between attitude towards entrepreneurship and entrepreneurship intention, which may be due to the fact in entrepreneurship, gender gaps do not dictate entrepreneurship intentions, supporting the findings of Yukongdi and Lopa (2017). As for university type, the lack of moderating effect may be due to a more standardized entrepreneurship support among different type of universities.

This study also reveals several real-life implications that can be useful to entrepreneurial ecosystems builders in Morocco and similar emerging economies. Since subjective norms and entrepreneurial role models significantly impact students' attitudes and intentions toward entrepreneurship, policymakers and educational institutions can take advantage of this to cultivate an environment where entrepreneurship is socially supported and visibly modeled by credible individuals that can be perceived as role models. This can be leveraged by informal entrepreneurial learning such as mentorship programs, alumni speaker series, and local success stories that students can identify with, as well as by the spread of positive societal views about entrepreneurship that can be modeled through family encouragement, peer support, and community engagement. In order to strengthen this societal shift, the inclusion of entrepreneurship narratives into media mainstreams and the normalization of entrepreneurial failure as part of the journey could be beneficial to reshape the public perception around entrepreneurship. In addition, the findings show no significant influence of entrepreneurship influencers on attitudes or intentions. This implies that influencer marketing to promote entrepreneurship is considered ineffective. Thus, other alternative approaches should be considered, like experiential entrepreneurship education in academic curriculums; for instance, business simulations, internship programs, and more that would be beneficial to develop practical entrepreneurship skills. Also, peer-to-peer role modeling and experiential learning through start-up competitions should be prioritized because they are important to provide students with functional entrepreneurial knowledge and hands-on entrepreneurship exposure, which is important based on our research because the moderating role of entrepreneurial education is non-significant, which showcases a gap in current programs and the need to move beyond theoretical education. By the same token, gender and university type did not act as moderators for entrepreneurial intentions. This should drive policymakers to eliminate stereotypes such as the idea of females are less interested in an entrepreneurial career and private university attendees are more driven to it. Instead, they should build national programs based on inclusion, not fragmentation and stimulate an environment of innovation, leadership, positive mindset, and problem-solving to create a thriving entrepreneurial environment.

While the study offers valuable insights, it still has certain limitations. To begin with, snowball sampling, a non-probability technique, is not a representative of the whole Moroccan youth population (Sedgwick, 2013). In addition, the demographic composition of the sample was skewed, with overrepresentation of bachelor-level students, young adults aged 18–25, and semi-private university attendees. Hence, the perspectives of the other categories may be underrepresented. Lastly, Morocco has its own cultural specificities which could make the findings not directly related to other emerging markets without considering local entrepreneurial norms.

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